

FROM THE ARCHIVES
Dec. 15, 1985

Cover Story
Paradise Lost

But the Rajneesh who has returned displays more than a touch of the current American fears. The guru of free sex now advocates strict use of condoms in order to stay clear of AIDS, and has an authorised recipe of foreplay which forbids kissing and oral sex but encourages licking of the earlobes.

Deep within himself, he is possibly afflicted by a sense of futility. When asked what he'd like to be remembered as after his death, his answer: "As a nobody."

Rajneesh is still the Peter Pan of the spirit, the priest of untrammelled desire, the unabashed advocate of opulence as a means to attain a bonanza of moksha. Even to many of his non-disciples, his bejewelled presence is like that of some lovable extra-terrestrial.

The romantic radiance of his Utopia, like the glitter of stones from his Valentino headbands, has a brittle shine. But, at the end of the day, it is the messiah himself who has to lead his flock. With the dream of a paradise shattered, and at a gouty 54, it is doubtful if he can rebuild it.

–Sumit Mitra with Richard Draper in Portland, Raj Chengappa in Pune

7,000
PEOPLE

In three years, the Rajneeshees turned an empty ranch into a township of 7,000 people. It had a fire department, police, restaurants, malls, townhouses, a 4,200-foot airstrip, a public transport system, a sewage reclamation plant, vineyards, orchards, a reservoir and a hospital

ZEN AND THE ART OF...

» The Osho International Foundation and smaller centres of the Osho movement are still active in India and around the world. They promote yoga and conduct various art therapy programmes

» Yoga and meditation became globally popular thanks to Osho's teachings

» Rajneeshpuram was one of the first to popularise organic farming practices on a large scale, including techniques like crop rotation and companion planting

» The Oregon sojourn continues to inspire docus such as *Wild Wild Country* and *Children of the Cult*

DID YOU KNOW?

Rajneeshpuram even built its own post office, with the ZIP code 97741

"I don't believe people can be equal. That is psychologically nonsense. A Picasso is a Picasso. A Rabindranath is a Rabindranath.... But society should give equal opportunity to everybody to be unequal. And in these four and a half years, we have managed to give [it to] everyone..."



— OSHO, INDIA TODAY *interview, Dec. 15, 1985*

the 'Rajneeshees'), but after getting into a headlock with the then ruling Janata government at the Centre, the Bhagwan and his followers pulled up their tents and left. Next destination: a 65,000-acre ranch in rural Oregon in the US, christened 'Rajneeshpuram'. Followers were invited to shift here where they would be free to put Osho's teachings into practice, including the free love, dynamic meditation and the satsang sessions. Within a few years, though, Rajneeshpuram too was embroiled in legal battles with the locals. Another hasty exit followed, and it was finally back to where it all started, in Koregaon Park, Pune, in 1985.

Osho was 'different' from the gurus India had seen till then. For one, he spoke openly about sex and the physical body, never being one to ask followers to give up their vices. Indeed, he believed that "science, the free market and birth control" could drag India out of poverty faster than anything else. He also flaunted his wealth, driving a Rolls Royce (he had a 93-strong fleet at one point in Oregon and aspired for more, "a different one to drive for every day of the year"), wore Rolex watches and Valentino headbands, and delivered sermons from a throne-like chair. The seer of sensualism was one of a kind, a guru whose east-west philosophical cauldron offered a confection box of ideas many in the West—and in India—found hard to resist. Osho passed away at his ashram in 1990 leaving no successors. The battle for his legacy continues. ■